Meanwhile, in the FRG, Willy Brandt's Social Democrats scored a victory in the September elections, opening a new era in West Germany's foreign policy. Suddenly, adherence to the Hallstein Doctrine was abandoned, paving the way for a period of rapprochement with the GDR and Moscow. His election spelt the end of the Christian Democrats' twenty-three-year dominance of the party that had been keen to work with the Western allies, align government policy with the United States and snub any overtures from the German Democratic Republic.

Brandt's process of understanding and reconciliation – or 'Ostpolitik' – was unbearably painful for some West German conservatives who screamed that money sent to Ulbricht to help the population, actually 'propped up his regime'. Others charged that GDR concessions promised on human rights were routinely ignored. After a decade in which FRG diplomacy had focused on snubbing the GDR's desire for recognition, Brandt let it be known that he was prepared to recognise the existence of two German States 'within the German nation'.

However, unlike Ulbricht who viewed 'Ostpolitik' as an opportunity for German-German negotiations, many in the SED Politburo united in scorn, fearing a warming relationship with Bonn. Honecker, of course, was also sceptical – and thus surfaced a new variant of antipathy with Ulbricht. At the twelfth session of the Central Committee in December 1969, Honecker set out a vision that was anything but unifying:

What they really want is to get a foot in the other fellow's door. One could dictate pages and pages on these gentlemen's ideas on the subject of infiltrating socialist countries according to their notorious 'grey plans' … First, they want to make themselves look open-minded and objective, then they want 'contacts' below what they call the threshold of international recognition to lull our political vigilance, and on top of that, they want the expertise of our specialists to help them close their own scientific gaps.